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Democracy Dies in Darkness

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## Warnings sound on economic ‘comeback’

Better days await, say Trump officials, as upheaval tests a nation

BY ABHA BHATTARAI

The economy is on shaky footing — a necessary moment of upheaval, the Trump administration says, as it overhauls the federal government with layoffs, funding cuts and turbulent new tariff policies. “A detox period,” Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent called it on Friday.

But the question for many Americans, who are already feeling down on the economy and glum about their financial futures, is: Are they willing to go through the pain of higher prices and job losses, even if it’s temporary, on the promise of better times ahead?

“There’s already a complete collapse of confidence — not just among consumers, but also investors and financial markets,” said Bernard Baumohl, chief global economist at the Economic Outlook Group. “Businesses are shaking their heads. They can’t quite figure out what’s happening in Washington.”

Americans are increasingly

SEE ECONOMY ON A12



We texted 1,000 Americans about Trump’s tariffs. Find out how they responded. A5



SALWAN GEORGES/THE WASHINGTON POST

Girls peek in a Damascus basement last month as civil defense members collect remains of bodies left there during the civil war.

## Syrians unearth Assad’s horrors

In the days after the ouster of Syrian President Bashar al-Assad, rescue workers began to receive calls about the trail of bodies that his loyalists had left in people’s homes.

For years, Syrians had stayed quiet about what they found upon returning to houses they had fled during the civil war’s worst periods. So vengeful were the government security forces that residents worried they might meet the same fate as the abandoned skeletons if they reported them.

Three months after Assad’s fall, doors hiding the shallow graves have been flung open. In the Damascus district of Sbeina last week, the bones in one basement were so incinerated that it was hard for civil defense workers to identify how many bodies were in the ash. At first, as Washington Post journalists observed, the men tried counting the pelvises; in the end, they found themselves guessing.

Many had stayed silent about the trail of bodies dumped in countless basements by regime forces. Rescue teams are now moving from home to home excavating remains.

BY LOUISA LOVELUCK  
AND ZAKARIA ZAKARIA  
IN DAMASCUS, SYRIA

Violence in Syria: Islamist security forces battle Alawite gunmen in broad outbreak. A8

Were there 20 here? Or more? One of the skulls seemed tiny, they noted, and there were bullet casings in the detritus. They wondered whether this was a family that had been killed together. None of the neighbors watching seemed to know.

A front line in Syria’s war, Sbeina had become a “security zone” in 2011, emptied of civilians as loyalist forces patrolled it. The people of the neighboring suburb of Hajar Aswad, besieged at the time, said hundreds of residents had disappeared after trying to escape through Sbeina. When families returned home to Sbeina from 2015 onward, they had locked the doors on their grim discoveries.

“If we had told the authorities, they would have said that we killed them,” said the basement’s owner, Ahmed Sayid. “What were we supposed to do?”

The Assad family, who fled Syria in December, are now in Jordan. SEE SYRIA ON A9

## In slashing agencies, DOGE eager to cast its targets as ‘fraud’

BY DAN DIAMOND  
AND FAIZ SIDDIQUI

Elon Musk and his allies in the U.S. DOGE Service have justified their efforts to dismantle federal agencies by invoking a frequent refrain: They’re merely targeting fraud, waste and abuse.

That idea has been echoed by President Donald Trump, who suggested there was significant

Critics say Musk is using overly broad language to build support for cuts

“fraud” in the Social Security program in his address to Congress on Tuesday night, and by Republicans who are eyeing potential cuts

to Medicaid and other federal spending.

“We found hundreds of billions of dollars of fraud,” Trump said in his remarks to Congress, after ridiculing several hundred million dollars’ worth of programs that he called “scams” and credited Musk with ending. He called on the Justice Department to probe Social Security spending: “We’re going to find out where that mon-

ey is going, and it’s not going to be pretty.”

The speech illustrated how Trump is trying to rally Americans behind Musk’s project to shrink the government — by attacking vast swaths of federal spending as fraudulent. Among the alleged fraudsters targeted by the Trump administration: foreign-aid programs such as the U.S. Agency for International Development,

clean-energy groups that received funding from the Biden administration, and organizations that specialize in diversity initiatives.

But independent watchdogs and outside analysts say Trump and Musk are using overly broad claims of fraud to build political

SEE DOGE ON A13

Philip Kennicott: Sale of buildings would reshape D.C. landscape. C1

## A new challenger rises to face undefeated death

Inside the scientific quest to reprogram our genes and reverse human aging

BY GRETCHEN REYNOLDS

For those hoping to cure death, and they are legion, a 2016 experiment at the Salk Institute for Biological Studies in San Diego has become liminal — the moment that changed everything. The experiment involved mice born to live fast and die young, bred with a rodent version of progeria, a condition that causes premature aging. Left alone, the animals grow frail and then die about seven months later, compared to a lifespan of about two years for typical lab mice.

But the Salk scientists had a plan to change the aging animals’ fate. They injected them with a virus carrying four genes that can reshape DNA and, in effect, make every cell in the rodents’ bodies young again. The scientists could even control the genes from outside the mice, turning them on and off to manage the safety and potency of the genetic changes.

The experiment worked: The animals lived 30 percent longer afterward, a marked improvement, if not quite a normal mouse lifespan.

And, with that, the longevity gold rush entered a new era. Tech titans and venture capitalists started throwing billions of dollars at labs exploring the technique, called cellular reprogramming. Experiments began on other mice, as well as worms and monkeys.

SEE LONGEVITY ON A6



ASTRID RIECKEN/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

### Thousands march to defend science

A crowd gathers at the Lincoln Memorial on Friday to defend science as a public good and a central pillar of social progress. Those there were protesting Trump administration cuts and funding freezes. Story, B4

## Russia pounces as U.S. halts aid

A MORE VULNERABLE UKRAINE IS STRUCK

Putin did ‘what anybody else would,’ Trump says

BY MICHAEL BIRNBAUM,  
SABRINA RODRIGUEZ  
AND KOSTIANTYN KHUDOV

President Donald Trump expressed understanding Friday for Russia’s stepped-up attacks on Ukraine after the White House halted military and intelligence aid to Kyiv this week, saying that he would resume help for the beleaguered country only when Ukrainian leaders agree that “they want to settle.”

The U.S. cutoff of aid to Ukraine has made the country significantly more vulnerable to Russian attack. With Kyiv no longer able to depend on U.S. intelligence assistance to aid its targeting or give it warning about Russian attacks, the Kremlin unloaded a massive missile assault on Ukraine overnight Thursday into Friday.

“I actually think he’s doing what anybody else would do,” Trump said in the Oval Office on Friday, when asked whether he was upset that Russian President Vladimir Putin was taking advantage of the U.S. halt in aid for Ukraine. “Probably anybody in that position would be doing that right now. He wants to get it ended. And I think Ukraine wants to get it ended, but I don’t

SEE RUSSIA ON A10

NATO: Military exercise comes amid concerns about U.S. support. A10

## Trump officials cut \$400M for Columbia

Administration accuses university of failing to quell antisemitism

BY SUSAN SVRLUGA,  
LAURA MECKLER  
AND HANNAH NATANSON

The Trump administration said Friday it was cutting off about \$400 million in federal contracts and grants to Columbia University, saying the school has failed to protect Jewish students from antisemitism on campus.

The administration took action just four days after announcing that several federal agencies were investigating Columbia. The school has been in the spotlight since last academic year when pro-Palestinian protesters erected tents on lawns at the center of the university’s Morningside Heights campus in Manhattan, and refused to take them down, in protest of the Israel-Gaza war.

The full list of canceled grants and contracts was not available Friday, nor was it clear what legal process the administration used to make its decisions. Cutting off funding is rare, and when it happens, it typically follows a lengthy

SEE COLUMBIA ON A4

### IN THE NEWS

**Eric Adams prosecution** The corruption case against the New York mayor should be permanently dismissed, an expert said. A14

**Pressuring D.C.** The transportation secretary asked the city to paint over its street murals, and not all activists would be surprised or sorry to see the most prominent one go. B1

**THE NATION**  
**Justice** Amy Coney Barrett sparked right-wing vitriol by ruling against the president. A2  
**Some federal workers** targeted by the U.S. DOGE Service are in administrative limbo. A3

**THE WORLD**  
**New Zealand’s** Maori may have a few tips for Americans resisting in the culture wars. A7  
**In February**, the extent of sea ice in the polar regions reached the lowest on record. A8

**THE ECONOMY**  
**A rollback** on cryptocurrency regulations is coming soon, Trump told CEOs and investors at a White House event. A8  
**The labor market** picked up 151,000 jobs in February despite layoffs among federal workers. A12

**THE REGION**  
**After decades** on the run, a man who admitted to fatally stabbing a stranger in Springfield was sentenced to 70 years. B1  
**Maryland’s** budget shortfall is wider than initially expected, according to projections from the comptroller. B1

**STYLE**  
**L.A. firefighters** basked in the glamour of the Oscars, a bright spot in a heartbreaking year for the agency. C1  
**SPORTS**  
**D.C. United’s** Jacob Murrell has attracted attention after scoring a spectacular clutch goal last weekend. D1

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